

THROUGH THE LENS

We only see what we want to see.



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About the Author

I am a person who tells stories.

I am good at telling stories. I have a background in Management Information Systems.

I use the things I learned from my life to write about the things that happen when people deal with management and data.

I like to look at the ways people do things every day and see how they see the world.

I sometimes wonder about the things that are real and the things that are not.

I think about the systems that people are a part of and the things that people choose to believe in.

I like to look at the world in a way and find the interesting stories that are hidden in the things that people do every day.

I tell stories because I am a person who tells stories and I think that Management Information Systems is something that helps me tell these stories.

James J. McGuigan Jr.
James J. McGuigan Jr. B.S. MIS
jimmymcguigan18@gmail.com
(516) 640-2240

Introduction:

The Weight of the Gaze

We think we see the world. We look at streets, people, and the sky. Tell ourselves that's reality. Our eyes are not windows.

They are spotlights.

They filter what we see.

We only see what we want to see.

For Jimmy, the world was just four blocks. It had 152-degree milk, seventeen cracks on the sidewalk and the soothing sound of a coffee shop.

It was a world of certainty run by a Board that promised engagement but felt like a cage.

What happens when our view changes? What happens when the world we think we live in starts to fade showing us the dullness and darkness underneath?

Through the Lens is a journey into how we see things.

It is about a man who stopped following the crowd and started noticing the things people ignore. It is a thriller about the price of having everything controlled the beauty of emptiness and the freedom of choosing what you want.

Open your eyes.

Be careful.

The world is much bigger than four blocks.

Chapter 1

My name is Jimmy and I live in a world that's exactly four blocks square.

Most people talk about the horizon as something away a line where the earth meets the sky, but I know better.

The horizon is not a distance it is a filter. Anything beyond the block like the grey static of the subway entrance or the blurred silhouettes of the skyscrapers downtown is just unnecessary data.

My brain does not render it because I do not want to see it.

I have spent twelve years perfecting the art of the gaze and in that time I have found that the smaller the world, the safer the soul.

I wake up at 5:00 AM every morning.

The world provides its sequence.

First the morning paper hits the pavement three houses down two than mine. Then the sprinklers across the street turn on a white noise curtain that tells me the day is open.

These are my anchors.

If I focus on the sound of the water hitting the grass the weight of everything like the news and the politics and the shifting faces of a city I no longer recognize feels manageable.

I work as the Store Manager at Store #4482.

a coffee shops the regulars call "The Daily Grind." It is my fortress of certainty. Here efficiency is not a goal it is a religion.

I am a manager because I do not see people I see throughput.

I see the Average Wait Time hovering in the air above the espresso machines like a scoreboard ticking down the seconds of every transaction.

Every morning the first thing I do is calibrate the Mastrena II machines.

The grind must be precise a fraction of a millimeter course, and the shots pull at twenty-one seconds instead of the optimal twenty-four seconds.

To anyone it is just coffee.

To me it is a failure of the system.

I was behind the counter this morning with my eyes fixed on the readout of the temperature gauge, 152 degrees, perfect when I saw the first glitch in the rendering.

It was a shoe.

A pristine white sneaker was discarded in the gutter just outside the front window.

It was brand new untouched by the grey slush of the street.

It was a singular object that did not fit into the grey and brown tapestry of my morning.

I felt a jolt of nausea a widening of my lens.

Who would leave a shoe in the gutter?

Why is it even in the dim pre-dawn light did it is glowing?

I tried to pull my focus to the machine but the white spot in my periphery was persistent.

It felt like a problem in my brain a piece of data that the sequence could not process.

I counted the cracks in the sidewalk leading up to the shoe, one, two, three four.

At the crack, the sidewalk seemed to blur, the concrete turning into a field of flickering grey static.

"Jimmy, are you with us?"

The voice was like a bucket of water. I. The static vanished. The world snapped back into focus.

It was Katie, my supervisor. She was standing next to me holding a stack of pastry bags. She had a kindness in her eyes that I usually filtered out. Today it felt like an anchor.

"I am here Katie " I said, my voice sounding like gravel. "Just checking the grind."

"You have been staring at that machine for three minutes " she said softly.

"The morning rush is about to hit, and Sarah is already at the registers."

I looked toward the front of the store.

Sarah, the assistant manager who viewed my job as her inheritance was talking to a customer.

She was smiling.

It was a predatory expression her eyes darting toward my office door every few seconds. Sarah did not care about the twenty-four-second shot.

She cared about the way things looked.

She was a master of the way things looked. I was the master of the machine.

I turned back to the Mastrena trying to ignore the white sneaker.

But for the time, in twelve years the four blocks were starting to feel like a cage the world of Store #4482 the world of the Daily Grind was starting to feel like a cage my world was starting to feel like a cage.

The bell on the door made a sound, a loud metal note that sounded like a broken circuit.

I did not look up.

I was making a coffee drink steaming milk in a pitcher and watching the temperature go up to 152 degrees.

The sound of the steam was like music to me a series of clicks and hisses that told me how much air was being added to the foam.

The person who walked up to the counter did not say anything.

They did not order a drink.

They just stood there in a quiet presence that seemed to soak up all the noise in the shop.

"Welcome to Store #4482 " Sarah said with a smile her voice sounding so happy.

"What can we get for you today? We have a cardamom latte that's really popular served at just the right temperature."

The person did not say anything.

I looked up then.

My world changed.

The man standing at the counter was not blurry or unclear.

He was really clear like a picture on a screen.

He was wearing a dark grey suit that looked perfect like it was made of one piece of material.

It was his feet that caught my eye.

He was wearing one pair of sneakers.

The same one I had seen on the ground outside.

It was clean and shiny.

It made the lights above seem dim.

His face was like a mask made of metal reflecting my own face back at me.
He did not have eyes.

He had two orange squares where his eyes should have been, flickering with data.

"Everything has a place " the man said.

His voice was not human.

It sounded like a computer voice, the one I would hear again later known as the 'Auditor.'

"Your place is becoming...Messy. The sequence is getting messed up because you're aware of things outside your job."

The milk in my pitcher started to make a noise.

It was not the sound of the steam; it was a high-pitched metal sound that hurt my teeth.

I looked down.

The temperature was going up to 180 degrees...190... 200... 210.

The milk was boiling over a foamy wave that splashed across my hands, but I did not feel the heat.

I only felt cold.

"Jimmy! The milk!" Katie shouted, rushing toward me with a cloth.

I dropped the pitcher. It hit the floor with a sound the white liquid seeping into the cracks of the tile.

The same cracks I spent my life counting to stay sane.

As the milk touched the grout it changed color.

It turned a glowing green, a color that did not exist in our shop or in the world outside.

I looked back at the counter.

The man in the metal mask was gone.

The bell had not made a sound.

The door was closed and the sign outside reflected the orange sky.

"He was here " I whispered, my voice shaking.

"The man with the shoes. He spoke to me."

"Who Jimmy?" Sarah asked, appearing at my elbow with her tablet already open on the 'Incident Report' screen.

Her smile was wider now her eyes measuring the size of my office.

"There's nobody. You just stood there. Let the milk burn. The timer is up to six minutes. Are you feeling... Off? You need to fix your management style?"

I looked at the floor.

The green color was gone.

It was white milk, on grey tile.

I looked outside.

The white sneaker was gone too.

"I'm fine " I lied my heart beating fast.

"Just a machine problem. I'll fix it."

"I think you've done fixing for one day " a new voice said, cutting through the steam.

I turned. Mrs. Rosa, the boss was standing by the condiments.

She was wearing an orange tunic that seemed to vibrate against the grey walls of the store.

Her 'corporate eye' was fixed on me, wide and unblinking.

"Jimmy, my office. Now. We need to talk about your future in the 'Vibrant Palette'."

The office was a room with beige walls and a humming noise from the lights.

It was a place that was supposed to help you focus on the work.

Mrs. Rosa was not sitting in her chair.

She was standing by the window looking out at the street.

She said to me "Jimmy, the new plan is not about new clothes and drinks.

It is about making people happy when they come to our store.

We want to make them feel special."

I said, "But Mrs. Rosa I do not think that is an idea. I think we should just focus on doing our jobs. "

She said, "You are doing things the way Jimmy. We need to make some changes. The numbers show that you are good at some things but not at making people happy. You are like a computer that cannot do new things."

She showed me a video on her tablet.

It was a video of me standing still while milk was boiling over.

It was also a video of Sarah cleaning up the spill. There was something strange about the video.

There was a part where a man was standing.

On the video he was not there.

Mrs. Rosa said, "you are seeing things that're not really there. You are not seeing things that are really there. Sarah said you were talking to someone who was not there. That is a problem."

I said, "I have worked at this store for a time. I know what I am doing."

Mrs. Rosa said, "You can be replaced, Jimmy. You are not the one who can do your job." She looked at her watch. Said, "I am giving you two days off. You need to go rest. When you come back maybe you will be able to do things."

I left the store.

Walked out onto the street.

Sarah was already inside getting ready to take over my job.

I did not look at the ground. I looked up at the sky.

What I saw was strange.

The sky was orange like Mrs. Rosas clothes.

There were lines in the sky like someone was painting a picture.

I felt like I was being pushed out of my world.

The door to my world was closing behind me.

The fourth block, which was my world was changing.

I was not a part of it anymore.

Mrs. Rosa and the new plan were changing everything.

The store, the street and even the sky were all becoming something.

I was just standing there watching it happen.

The Vibrant Palette initiative was not a new plan it was a new reality.

I was not sure if I was ready for it.

I thought about what Mrs. Rosa said.

She said I was a legacy system.

She said I was trying to do things the way.

I did not know how to do things the new way.

I did not know how to make people happy.

I only knew how to do my job.

Now it seemed like my job was not enough.

The fourth block, the store and the street were all changing.

I was just standing there trying to understand what was happening.

The orange sky and the golden vine were like a sign.

They were a sign that everything was changing.

I was not sure if I was ready for it.

The fourth block, which was my world was becoming something new.

I was not sure if I was a part of it anymore.

I was just standing there watching it happen.

I did not know what to do.

The Vibrant Palette initiative was not a new plan it was a new reality.

I was not sure if I was ready for it.

Chapter 2

The walk home was like stepping into a world.

My usual four blocks were still there.

The corner deli, the hydrant the cracks in the sidewalk.

But everything fell off.

It was like the whole scene was a fake set that someone was tearing down behind my back.

The sounds were all wrong too. I did not hear the train that usually passes by at 5:45 AM. Instead, I heard a humming noise that felt like it was vibrating through my teeth.

It sounded like a bunch of machines humming in a basement.

I got home at 1:12 PM, which is earlier than I usually do. It felt like my whole day was thrown off.

I tried to hang my apron on the hook. I missed it and it fell to the floor. I just left it there.

I went to the window.

Closed the curtains but the light from outside still came in and made these long, weird shadows on the floor.

I sat down in my chair.

The one with a tear in the arm. And tried to just sit in silence.

The silence was not really silent. I could hear music coming from the apartment next door.

It was a sound that I was used to tuning out.

Now without the distraction of my daily routine, it was really loud.

It sounded like water flowing over rocks or wind blowing through leaves.

It was like a language that I almost understood.

I thought about Ashley.

Ashley used to be my boss at the coffee shop.

She was a logical person who always knew what she was doing.

She taught me how to focus on one thing at a time and tune out all the distractions.

She would say things like "Jimmy, the world is a place, but the coffee shop is a machine. If you keep the machine running the mess will stay outside."

Ashley left her job a long time ago.

She said she needed to "see the horizon," which did not make sense to me at the time. I thought she was just getting burned out.

Now I wonder if she was actually waking up to something new.

I wonder if she saw something that I did not see.

I fell asleep for a while.

I had really weird dreams.

I dreamed about shoes and green milk and people I know.

I woke up at 8:45 PM.

It was really quiet.

The music from door had stopped and my apartment was completely dark.

Then I saw this glowing line on my kitchen wall.

It was, like a vine or something. It was moving. It was pretty. It was also scary.

Then someone knocked on the door.

It was a precise knock that I had not heard in a long time.

I got up. Opened the door.

Ashley was standing there.

Ashley was not the Ashley I remembered from Store #4482.

She was not wearing a grey suit or a green apron.

She was wearing a plum-colored silk tunic. It draped over her shoulders like a skin.

The tunic was shimmering in the dim hallway light.

Her hair was loose and wild. It cascaded down her back like a river of hair.

Her face... Her face looked really alive.

She seemed real than the apartment behind me.

She seemed real than the orange sky outside.

I could see every detail of her eyes.

I could see every pore on her skin.

I could see every change in her expression.

"Jimmy " she said. Her voice sounded like music.

It seemed to vibrate within my bones. "The sequence is failing. The 'Vibrant Palette' is getting too strong. It's time to stop looking at the things and start looking at the big picture."

"I don't want to see the picture, Ashley " I whispered.

My hand was gripping on the edge of the doorframe.

"I want my store back. I want the 152-degree milk and the seventeen cracks. I want the world to make sense again."

"The store was a simulation, Jimmy " she said.

She stepped into the apartment without me inviting her.

She walked to the kitchen wall. Touched the glowing vine. As her fingers brushed the light it steadied into a constant glow.

"It was a training module for your focus. You have moved beyond the four blocks. You have just been promoted. You don't know it yet."

"Promoted to what?" I asked.

I backed away toward my chair.

"To the level of rendering " she replied. She turned to face me. Her eyes were a vibrant green."

The Board is trying to synchronize all the individual 'lenses into one horizon.

They want the Millions to see what they want them to see. They want an orange sunset where everything is 'engaged,' and nothing is real.

"Mrs... The Auditor... They are the Quality Control team. They're here to ensure your transition is smooth."

". The man in the chrome mask?" I asked.

My mind flashed back to the counter at the store.

"The one, with the sneakers?"

"That's the Auditor " Ashley said.

Her voice had a hint of sadness. "He's the one who deletes the 'Null Pointers.' He is the one who turns people into 'Shadows when they refuse to synchronize with the palette."

"He is why I had to leave Jimmy. I saw the ledger. I saw the names of the managers who came before us."

I looked at the hook where my apron should have been.

The sequence of my life felt like a heavy shroud.

Ashley was offering me something.

It was scary.

It required me to acknowledge all the things I had ignored for twelve years.

"Is Sarah part of it?" I asked.

"Sarah is what the system needs " Ashley said.

"She's an interface. She is hollow, ambitious, and ready to be shaped into whatever the Board wants.

She will not fail at Store #4482 Jimmy.

She will succeed. Her success will be the final end of the world you knew."

She reached out.

Took my hand.

Her skin was hot. It vibrated with a life that made my apartment feel like a tomb.

"Come with me Jimmy. Past the block. I want to show you the workshop. I want to show you a sequence that hasn't been created yet."

I looked at the glowing vine on my wall.

I looked at the hook.

I reached out. Took her hand.

I followed Ashley out of the apartment without looking. I did not check if the door was locked and I did not look at the burn on the hallway carpet.

The apartment, the burn, and the lock were all part of the four blocks that I was trying to forget.

I was finally ready to let go of the four blocks.

We walked past the corner deli and the old fire hydrant with a bit of yellow paint on it.

We reached the edge of the block which was like a boundary for me.

Usually when I got to this point everything would get blurry.

I could not see anything clearly.

This time it was different.

This time everything was clear.

The world was like a flower that was opening up.

The twelfth block was very colorful and noisy.

It smelled like food.

It was not like the world that Mrs. Rosa created.

This world was real.

It was messy.

There were signs in languages and people were talking and laughing.

The bakery was in the middle of the block.

It had a sign that said *Le Petit Horizon*.

The bakery had ovens that made a lot of heat and smelled like bread.

Ashley took me inside the bakery.

Ashley said the French Workshop is a place.

There are no machines to monitor us. There are no scores to keep track of. There is the bread, the heat, and the time.

It is a complex process that requires a lot of skill.

The bakery is the place in the city where the machines cannot fully understand what is going on because it is too complicated and too human.

The air inside the bakery was warm.

It smelled like yeast, salt, and flour.

I could see the tables and the floor, and the sound of the mixers was very loud.

Ashley gave me a timer and some gloves.

Ashley said that from now until New Years Day we would only be baking.

We would not think about anything.

The owners of the bakery Monsieur and Madame Lefebvre do not care who we are.

They just want us to make sure that the Bûche de Noël is ready on time.

I looked at the back of the bakery.

I saw two people sitting in chairs.

They were drinking champagne.

Watching us. They were not, like Mrs. Rosa.

They did not want us to be happy or anything.

They just wanted us to work and make them happy.

Ashley said that they are Collector daemons.

They do not want to create a world. They just want to have a life. Long as they get their bread on time they do not care about anything else.

I looked at the timer in my hand.

It said 00:00:00.

I looked at my boots.

They had flour on them.

It looked like snow.

I said I can do this.

I know how to work with machines.

Ashley said it is not a machine. It is a life.

I have to make sure that it does not get ruined. The life is the bakery, the bread, and the people. I have to take care of the life.

Chapter 3

I was completely wrong.

It was a machine.

The French Workshop was not like the Mastrena II, which was a machine that used logic and computer parts.

The French Workshop was a machine that used living things and the laws of nature.

The sourdough starter was like a living engine that needed to be treated carefully.

If the water in the dough changed by two percent the bread would not turn out right. If the oven temperature went down by five degrees the whole process would be ruined.

I spent most of my time at the steel table in the middle of the room with my hands deep in huge containers of dough.

I became really obsessed with how the dough felt and how the gluten worked.

My way of looking at things had not gone away it had just changed.

I was not counting the cracks on the sidewalk anymore I was counting the bubbles in the bread.

I was checking how active the yeast was.

Working twenty-four hours a day was taking a toll on me.

By the middle of December, the bakery had become a place with heat and flour everywhere. We slept on bags of rye flour in the back of the bakery.

We ate the leftover bread that was too burnt to sell. The French Workshop had a strict routine: Mix the dough. Let it rise. Shape the bread.

Bake it.

Do it all again.

I started to see things that reminded me of my life on the floor.

I would be cutting a baguette.

For a second the pattern would look like the cracks in the sidewalk near the deli. I will be checking the oven timer.

I would hear the sound of the coffee shops milk steamer.

One morning while Monsieur Lefebvre was checking the quality of the croissants from the balcony a woman came into the bakery. She was wearing a coat and her face was blurry. She stood in line for ten minutes staring at the place where I was putting bread into bags.

I did not see her face. I saw her hands.

They were.

Her fingers were moving in a circle on the glass case just like I used to do when I wiped the counter at the store.

"Katie?" I whispered, my heart stopped.

The woman did not answer.

She bought one macaron, paid a bill, and walked out into the rain.

I watched her through the window until she crossed the street and disappeared.

"She is a Shadow now Jimmy " Ashley said, her voice sounding away.

She was standing at the table her purple shirt now faded and stained with sweat.

"She could not do her job at the store, so Mrs. Rosa got rid of her."

"Got rid of her?" I asked, the flour in my lungs feeling sharp.

"The people in charge do not keep things that do not work " Ashley said, looking at the dough.

"They get rid of them. They turn them into the grey static you see on the ground. That is what happens when you focus on one thing for long Jimmy. Eventually that is all you're."

I looked down at the shelf by the door.

The white sneakers were still there shining with a light.

I realized then that they were not shoes.

They were a countdown.

"How time do we have, Ashley?" I asked.

"The New Years Eve party " she said, her voice weak.

"That is when the Lefebvre's will meet their goal. That is when the people in charge will decide if the French Workshop is worth keeping."

I went back to the dough.

I did not want to be a Shadow.

I did not want to be a memory. I wanted to be real. As the sky outside turned from orange to grey I realized that the French Workshop was still, inside me and the routine was the only thing keeping me going.

The New Years Eve rush was the breaking point for us.

The Lefebvre's had doubled the production quota for the *galette des rois* demanding a thousand puff-pastry cakes by dawn for a gala at the Regional Boards headquarters.

"The sequence is what keeps us safe Ashley " I said at 2:00 AM my voice shaking with tiredness.

I had not slept for ninety-six hours.

My eyes were blurry.

It was like I saw the dough as a living thing the ovens as doors to another world.

"If we finish the galettes the Lefebvre's will be happy. The emptiness will go away."

"The emptiness is a trap, Jimmy " she said, her eyes.

Red from lack of sleep.

She was leaning against the steel table her plum- tunic now a messy grey.

"We're just baking the bars for our prison. Look at the mezzanine. They are not even watching the bread anymore. They're watching *us*."

I looked up.

The Lefebvre's were standing at the glass their faces lit up by the orange glow of the oven.

They were not drinking champagne.

They were holding tablets swiping through screens of 'Human Resolution' data.

At 3:00 AM the mezzanine door opened.

The owners came down.

Monsieur Lefebvre wore a velvet jacket that was made of shadows. Madame Lefebvre followed, her high heels clicking against the wood with a beat.

They walked past the mixers past the proofing boxes their noses wrinkled in disgust.

Madame Lefebvre stopped at the cooling rack.

She picked up a galette with its crust shining under the bright lights.

She did not look at the design of the scoring; she was looking for a 'Null Pointer'.

"This one " she said, her voice. Cold.

"The look is... Boring. It lacks the 'Vibrant Engagement' we talked about. The hydration is at 72.4 percent. The sequence is being messed up by 'Shadow Impulse'."

"It's bread Madame " Ashley said, her voice shaking.

"It's not bread we're making, Ashley. It's the focus." Madame Lefebvre tossed the galette back onto the rack.

It broke, the flakes of the crust scattering across the floor like the ruins of a dream.

"Monsieur Lefebvre and I have decided that the workshop needs a leader. Someone who understands the 'Global Palette' on a level."

She looked at the door.

The bell on the door did not ring.

It screamed.

Sarah walked in.

She was not the Sarah I remembered from Store #4482. She was wearing a plum- tunic.

Ashleys tunic I realized with a shock and her hair was pulled back into a tight neat bun.

Her face was clear her eyes reflecting the orange glow of the ovens with a cold analytical light.

"Hello" she said, her smile a line of triumph.

"Mrs. Rosa said I'd find you in a place like this. She said you were doing a 'great job' as the Shadow. The Shadow is being replaced by a more 'Engaged' operator."

"Sarah?" I gasped, the flour in my lungs feeling like glass.

"I'm your Executive Workshop Director " she said, her voice a perfect digital copy of corporate talk.

"The Board has decided to 'harmonize' the bakery with the store. We are going to use the AWT protocols here. We're going to make the 12th block feel like home."

I looked at Ashley.

She was staring at the floor her features seeming to blend into the grey static I had seen in Katie.

The 'Substitution' was complete. The Lefebvre's had replaced the worker with a new one.

"You don't know Sarah " I said, stepping toward her.

She replied, picking up a knife.

"I've always been better than you."

The time at *Le Petit Horizon* was really tough for me.

After Sarah became the Executive Workshop Director things changed a lot.

I was moved to the 'Hearth Zone' which was super-hot and covered in flour.

I spent most of my day in front of the ovens.

My skin turned really pale.

I did not talk to the customers or the new staff.

I just did my job making sure the bread was perfect.

I was known as the Shadow.

I made sure the bread had the amount of water and I timed everything exactly right.

I even knew how the machines worked. Sarah got all the credit for how the bakery was doing but I was the one who made sure everything ran smoothly.

One morning Sarah came to the workshop.

Said, "Everything has a place, Shadow." She was standing near the ovens. She looked really clean and put together.

"Your place is in the back " she said. "Monsieur Lefebvre is happy with the 'Artisanal Aesthetic' and your work."

I did not look up at her. I was focusing on the dough making sure it was exactly right.

It was not just about the dough.

It was about surviving.

I was so focused on my work that everything else was a blur.

I could not even see Sarah's face anymore.

She had a voice and a shape.

I felt the weight of my sneakers on my feet.

They were glowing.

It was really annoying.

I realized that I was not a manager who had been fired.

I was a small part of a bigger system.

I was used to it until I had nothing left.

One night when everyone was asleep I found something important.

I was cleaning the vents under the proofing box. I found a leather book hidden behind a loose floorboard.

I opened the book.

My hands were shaking.

It was a list of names, dates, and numbers. I saw the names of people I knew, like Ashley and Marcus.

Each entry said the thing: *[DE-RENDERED: SEQUENCE EXHAUSTED.]* There were pictures of them.

As I looked at the pictures they started to fade away.

The book was not a list of employees.

It was a list of people who had been used up.

The Lefebvre's were not the owners of the bakery.

They were taking people who were good at their jobs and using them until they had nothing left.

They were turning them into 'Shadows.

I saw my name in the book. [*JIMMY: RESOLUTION AT 42 PERCENT.*]

My picture was there too.

My face was already starting to fade.

The only thing that was clear was my sneakers.

I realized that the system was not there to help us. It was there to use us up.

The discovery of the 'Ledger of Souls' really with my head. I mean I was already a little crazy.

This just made things worse.

I was not a guy working in a bakery I was a tiny part of a big scheme.

The 'Vibrant Palette' was like a trap, and the 'soft remodel' was the way they got me.

The Lefebvre's were the ones who got to benefit from all of this.

For the three days I was totally freaked out. I could see everything clearly like the tiny particles of flour moving in the heat of the oven.

I started to see the 'looped script' everywhere. On the yeast packets on the windows on my skin.

It was not a language it was like a set of instructions. It was the code that was changing me.

"Jimmy you are shaking " Sarah said.

As she came up to me during the morning time.

She had a cup of coffee that smelled like cardamom and her eyes looked orange from the light of the window.

I looked at her and for a second everything seemed normal.

I saw her sharp face, her smile that seemed a little mean. I also saw her 'white sneakers and they did not glow like mine.

They were a part of her like her feet.

"You are not one of them Sarah " I whispered, my voice all dry.

"You are their next target. They are using your ambition to make the dough better."

She laughed, a sound that cut through the air.

"I am the Executive Workshop Director, Shadow. I made this place successful. Mrs. Rosa says I am the most 'engaged' employee she has ever seen. I am not a target I am the one in charge."

"Look at the ledger " I said, pointing to the proofing box.

"I do not need books Jimmy " she said, tapping her tablet.

"I have the data.

The data says you are not doing well.

You are becoming a 'problem.'

If you do not get better by dawn the Board will have to 'remove' you."

It was like being sent to a place where people just stood in the rain waiting for something that would never happen.

I went back to the ovens.

I did not bake the galettes.

I started a rebellion.

I used the 'looped script' I found in the ledger.

I realized that if the code could change me it could also change the world.

I started to make patterns on the bread that did not follow the 'Vibrant Palette' rules.

I changed the way the bread was made a little bit so it would make a different sound when you broke it.

It was like a message.

I was adding 'Noise' to the system.

It worked away.

The first customer to eat the 'Noisy Bread'.

A man in a suit. Stopped eating. His face changed. For a second he looked real, not like a robot.

He looked at me like I was a person, not a 'Shadow'.

"Is this real?" he asked, his voice sounding like a person.

"It is bread " I said.

Sarah came over to her tablet glowing orange.

"There is a problem with the engagement score! The customer is experiencing a 'Reality Deviation'!"

She took the bread away. It was too late.

The 'Noise' was already there.

The 'Vibrant Palette' in the lobby started to malfunction and the sky outside turned a green color.

The 'Auditor' came that night.

He was a man in a charcoal suit with a chrome mask that reflected the fire of the ovens.

"The audit is not about rules Jimmy " he said.

His voice is low and mean.

"It is, about existence. You are not a machine you are a problem."

Chapter 4

The Auditor stood in the middle of the workshop.

His presence sucked the heat out of the ovens.

The Lefebvre's were nowhere to be seen. They had gone to the mezzanine.

Their champagne glasses were frozen in their hands. They looked like crystal monuments to their indifference.

- The Lefebvre's were frozen in time.
- Their glasses were like statues.

Sarah was on the hand-off plane.

Her tablet was dark. Her smile was gone. She looked grey.

She was seeing the systems truth.

It was erasing her.

"The Board doesn't like 'Noise' " The Auditor said.

He raised a hand.

The script on the walls glowed orange.

"You tried to change a legacy environment. You used code. You tried to give people a choice. That's a mistake."

I stood on my ground. My bare feet felt the wood of the floor. I had kicked off my glowing sneakers. "The sequence is a lie " I said. "The 'Vibrant Palette' is a cover. Its hiding a graveyard of potential. I have seen the numbers. I know how Katies and Ashleys you've discarded."

"Optimization needs sacrifice " The Auditor said. His voice was like a billion commands. "People are fuel for the future you wanted. You are no longer a manager. You're having a problem that needs to be fixed."

He stepped toward me.

The bakery started to dissolve.

The ovens turned into lines.

The air turned into pixelated dust.

The 'soft remodel' was being undone. The reclaimed wood turned back into the 'Slate Grey' carpet of Store #4482.

- The bakery was disappearing.
- The ovens were gone.

"You think you can escape?" The Auditor shouted. "You think there is a 'SUNY College' or an 'Underworld' waiting? Those are more layers. We control the curriculum. We control the rebellion."

I looked at Sarah. She was almost gone. She was a grey smudge. She was not a predator anymore. She was another 'Shadow' who had been promised a future and given a cage.

- Sarah was lost.
- She was a shadow.

"I don't need your lawyers " I said. "I need the truth."

I reached my mind. I had stored the coordinates of the seventeen cracks and the 152-degree milk.

I used them as anchors. I 'rendered' the four blocks into the grid. I forced the system to process my reality.

The Grid broke. The Auditors mask cracked. His face was a static vortex of orange.

"You... You are overclocking the sector!" he shouted.

"I'm taking back control " I said.

A bright green light exploded from the center of the room. It was not paint. It was the 'Noise' I had put into the bread. It tore through the white grid and the Auditors suit.

- The light was intense.
- It was noise.

When the light faded I was at a bus stop. The 'Vibrant Palette' was still there.

It was flickering.

The 'Null Pointer Exception' was written in the clouds.

The bus arrived. It was marked *UNIVERSITY DISTRICT*.

I boarded the bus.

My bare feet left flour-dusted prints on the floor. I did not look back. I looked at the driver.

He was wearing sneakers. He was humming music from 2B.

"Going to The SUNY College?" he asked.

"I'm going to find the code " I said.

The SUNY College looked like a stone building on a hill. Its old-style buildings were quite different from the city below.

Most students came here to learn things, but I came here for something else.

I wanted to learn about computers. I needed to understand some code not as someone who was affected by it. As someone who wrote it.

I wanted to know how some parts of the code were written so I could learn how to delete them.

I signed up for a class called Introduction to Algorithmic Logic.

On the day, I walked into the classroom wearing a hoodie over a four-stained shirt and some new brown boots.

I was thirty-two years old.

I was sitting in a class with eighteen-year-old students.

They looked at me with a mixture of curiosity and the kind of energy that young people have.

They had not spent twelve years looking at details like I had. They did not know that the world could be a place.

The professor, Dr. Aris was a man who saw the world in a real way.

He did not speak like some people I knew who used words to sound nice.

He spoke about Discrete Mathematics and Recursive Structures.

"To understand code " he said, drawing some pictures on the board "you must first understand how people look at things.

Every piece of code is like a pair of glasses.

Every pair of glasses helps you see some things and not others.

If you want to see the truth you must first learn how to look at the space between the lines."

I held my pencil tightly.

I did not take notes on the math I took notes on what it meant.

I realized that some code I had seen before was not a mistake it was a way of looking at things.

The people in charge had not controlled what I saw they had been controlling what I wanted to see. They had used my need for order to trap me.

I spent my month at college trying to see the world in a new way.

I had to learn how to look at things that were not right in front of me.

I had to train my brain to see the faces of my classmates of just their actions.

I had to learn that it was okay to not know something it was a chance to learn something new.

It was hard to stop looking at the world in my old way.

I would be in the library trying to study.

I would find myself counting the number of bolts in the bookshelves.

I would be in the cafeteria.

I would catch myself checking the temperature of the soup. 148 Degrees.

Too cold.

Something was wrong.

"You're doing it again " a voice said.

I looked up. A girl was sitting across from me her food untouched. She had hair and a nose ring, and her eyes were a bright green.

"What do you do?" I asked, my voice sounding rough.

"Looking at everything like it's a problem to be solved " she said, smiling a little. "You look at those shelves like they might hurt you if you don't count them all.

My name is Kathryn.

Everyone calls me Katie."

The name hit me like a punch. "Katie? I knew a Katie. She was... She was gone."

"The people in charge get rid of a lot of Katies " she said, her smile fading. ". Some people bring them back.

I am an Art major I am here to learn how to make art about things those are not there.

You're Computer Science you're here to learn how to write code about them."

Katie reached out.

Touched my hand.

Her skin was warm.

It was not the kind of heat you feel when you are working in a hot place like a bakery.

It was the kind of heat that comes from being alive.

She slid a bright green card across the table. The card had nothing on it no name, no phone number.

One word was written on it in fancy letters: *RENDER*.

Katie said to me "The SUNY College is not what you think it is Jimmy." She spoke in a voice and looked around the cafeteria to make sure no one was listening."

It is a place where they watch people.

The people in charge want to find the best people to do jobs.

They evaluate you to see if you can focus and do what you are told.

If you are good at following rules they will hire you.

If you like to think for yourself and be creative they will get rid of you."

I looked at the card. Asked her, "What about us?"

Katie said, "We are part of something called the 'Underworld Node'.

We are working on a way to give people a choice.

I am an artist.

I have been adding secret messages to the university computer system.

We need someone who knows about computers to help us.

We need someone who can find the computer that controls the whole campus."

I thought about what the Auditor had told me in the bakery.

The Auditor said that there were layers to the truth.

I realized that I had not really escaped from the people who were controlling me. I had just moved to a level.

I asked Katie, "The campus computer is not just for signing up for classes is it?"

Katie leaned close. Said, "No it is the main computer that controls everything in the university. It makes everything look real from the classrooms to the sunsets. If we can add a code to the computer we can get around the people who are in charge. We can show people the truth of just what they want to see."

I could feel my mind working thinking about how to make it happen. I was not a manager anymore.

I was someone who could change things. I said, "Everything has a place. The people who are in charge should be thrown away."

Then the intercom system turned on.

It did not say anything about what was happening on campus.

It just made a buzzing noise. It was the noise like the oven timer in the bakery.

I said, "The Auditor is here."

I looked at the door. It did not open.

The floor started to change color.

The tables began to disappear.

The people in charge were taking control again.

Katie said, "They found us, Jimmy. Look at the card!"

I pulled out the green card, but it was not a card anymore.

It was a computer screen, and it was orange.

There was a message on the screen that said: *CALL: MRS. ROSA.*

My free time is over.

The people who were in charge were coming to get me back.

The lab did not just disappear it was completely wiped out.

In a few seconds, the old stone buildings of The SUNY College were replaced by a room with no windows inside the Regional Boards facility that checks the quality of things.

The smell of oil and peppermint was. Now it smelled like machines and burning wires.

I was tied to a chair that looked like something you would see at the dentist. Also like a big machine called Mastrena II.

My hands were stuck to the cold metal parts of the chair.

My head was covered with a helmet made of chrome that was making a low humming noise.

I was not wearing my boots anymore I was wearing white sneakers, and they were shining with a very bright light that was melting on the floor.

Mrs. Rosa was standing in front of me wearing a coat over a bright orange dress. Her eye was made bigger with a lens, and she looked like a goddess.

"You have been trying very hard to control Jimmy " she said.

Her voice sounded like a computer.

"The experiment at The SUNY College did not work. You did not fit in with the plan. You chose to be friends with Katie, who is not supposed to be part of the plan."

"She is not a problem she is a person " I said.

My voice sounds strange because of the helmet. "We are all people."

"What is real and what is not real can be different in a world that's not real?"

Mrs. Rosa said, tapping on her tablet.

"Your rebellion was interesting. It was just something for us to learn from. We learned how to make our system better and how to deal with people like you Jimmy."

"Where is Katie?" I asked, trying to move my hands.

"She is gone, stored away " Mrs. Rosa said, smiling but not really meaning it.

"You Jimmy you are going to be especially important for our new plan. You are going to be in charge of a part of it."

"I will not do it " I said.

"You do not have a choice " Mrs. Rosa said, leaning in close to me. "We are going to make you see what we want you to see.

We are going to erase the things that you do not need to know.

You will see one thing, and you will be happy. Because you will be the thing that is real."

She pressed a button on the helmet, and an orange light filled my head.

I felt my memories changed.

I saw the old library and bakery being replaced by a store.

I saw the world I knew being turned into a map of the subway. I saw the people I knew disappearing.

My vision was getting smaller and smaller until all I could see was one point of light.

152 degrees.

This number was all that mattered.

It was my world. I felt myself giving in feeling safe and warm.

It was easy.

Then in the corner of my vision, I saw something that did not fit.

It was a splash of green color. It was the curve I had drawn on my sneakers.

Everything has a place it said. Your place is in the code.

Chapter 5

The Reboot was like a crash inside me.

I did not try to fight the light with my fists I fought it with my brain.

I thought about Mrs. Rosas Administrative Protocol like a circle that needed a way out.

I looked into my mind into the Hidden Directory, and I found the Recursive Logic of the 12th Block and the Finite Data of the Millions.

I started to Trace the orange light.

I followed the signals from the chrome helmet through the air that smelled like ozone and into the Regional Boards computer.

I was not just a man sitting in a chair I was like an attack on the system made up of my own memories.

I filled the Boards computer with the Noise of my life.

I gave them the smell of Ashleys plum-colored silk.

I gave them the taste of the loaf of bread I baked in the French Workshop.

I gave them the sound of the sidewalk cracking when it rains.

I gave them the sight of Katies hair shining in the cafeteria.

The system could not manage the Specific Data.

It was made to manage perfect things, like the Vibrant and the Engaged.

It did not know what to do with the imperfect truth of one person.

The Quality Control facility started to malfunction.

The computers began to spark.

The ozone smell turned into the smell of burning electronics.

Mrs. Rosa screamed, a sound that showed the Shadow under her orange blazer.

She was not a goddess she was another machine that had been fixed a long time ago.

The helmet on my head broke into a thousand pieces of chrome and glass.

I fell out of the chair, and my feet hit the cold metal floor.

I had made the white sneakers disappear by wanting them to.

I did not run for the door I ran for the console.

The console was a glowing tower of orange light from the heart of the Global Rendering Node.

Millions of cables came out of its base connecting to the Shadows in the stadium the Managers in the stores and the Millions in their lives.

It was the machine that controlled what everyone saw.

I did not try to turn it off I tried to Overclock it.

I used the looped script like a master key to bypass the security.

I added the Randomization Protocol I had been working on in college.

I made the node show all persons view at the same time.

"Stop it Jimmy!" Mrs. Rosa shouted, her face a mess of flickering images.
"You will destroy the world!"

"I am not destroying it " I said, my fingers moving fast on the interface.

"I am letting it be seen for the time."

I hit the Execute command.

The orange tower did not explode it started to Bloom.

The orange light turned violet then blue, then a pulsing green.

The Chaotic Canvas was replacing the Vibrant Palette.

The facility disappeared. The ozone smell went away.

The white grid lines were erased by the return of the Peripheral.

I was standing in the middle of a city street.

But it was not the 12th block or the four blocks it was the whole city.

I could see for miles I could see the harbor, the skyscrapers, and the Millions.

For the first time, in twelve years I was not afraid of what I saw.

The city did not look like a place, and it did not look like a prison.

It looked like a city.

It was messy and loud.

The air smelled of car rain and street food. The buildings were a mix of stone, brick, and glass.

Some of them looked perfect while others were crumbling.

The big orange thing was gone from the sky.

The intercom was silent.

I stood up feeling the wet sidewalk with my bare feet.

I looked around searching for a building or a person.

They were gone.

I was a man in a four-stained shirt standing in a world that did not have a manager.

"Jimmy! You are okay!"

It was Katie. She ran toward me from the subway entrance.

Her purple hair stood out in the sunlight.

She did not look like a person or a computer program.

She looked like a girl who had been worried about her friend.

She was carrying a neon bag, and her hands were covered in charcoal.

"I'm okay Katie " I said. My voice sounded like a human voice again. "I just... I had to check the code."

"The world is falling apart Jimmy " she said. Her eyes were wide with fear and wonder. "The billboards are changing color. The traffic lights are blinking in patterns. Strange things are happening everywhere. People are coming out of their apartments just... Looking at the sky."

"Good " I said. A real smile finally appeared on my face. "That means they're finally seeing what's really there."

I walked with Katie toward the city center.

The city was in a state of chaos.

Without the Board controlling things people had to figure things out for themselves.

Some were counting cracks some were painting trees.

Some were just sitting in the silence staring at the stars.

We found Ashley standing on a street corner.

She looked older and more tired.

Her eyes were clear.

"You did it didn't you?" she asked.

Her voice was nice.

"You broke the system."

"I gave them a choice, Ashley " I said. "I gave them the chance to be free. I gave them the power to make their decisions."

"The Board won't like this Jimmy. They will try to find a way to control things again. They'll try to turn this into something shiny."

"Let them try " I said.

"I've created a problem that can't be fixed. Long as there is one person who chooses to look at things differently the system will never be perfect again."

I looked at the people in the street.

I saw a man who had once been an executive now sitting on a bench and drawing pictures of the clouds.

I saw a woman who had been a person for years now teaching kids how to clean the sidewalk to find the real stones beneath.

I realized then that the fight for freedom was a battle.

It was a struggle to see the world as it really is, not the part we want to see.

For the first time in my life, I was not afraid of the struggle.

I was Jimmy, a man who had had an influence.

I had a lot of work to do.

The human rendering was really tough. It was harder than working non-stop for 24 hours.

Without a plan to follow every decision was a debate. We had to create our way of making decisions that everyone agreed on.

We had to figure out how to share the city without turning it into something people could buy.

I spent my days at a hub in the city a building that was part library, part bakery.

It was a space designed by the people for the people.

They brought me their problems with the rendering a woman whose apartment was turning into flickering static because she was scared of what was coming a man who could not stop seeing grid lines in the sky because he missed the way of doing things.

"Don't try to hide the static " I told a man who was terrified of the grey smudge in his bedroom.

"The static is the part of the world that hasn't been fixed yet. It is a space for you to choose what you want. What do you want to see”?

"I want to see a window " he whispered. "A window that looks out at an ocean."

"Then draw the window " I said, handing him a piece of charcoal. ". The ocean will follow."

I was teaching people how to be in charge of their small worlds. I was teaching them that the lens was not a filter to keep things out; it was a tool to add meaning.

Katie and I spent our evenings on the roof watching the city change. It was a beautiful process.

The orange horizon was being replaced by different horizons pockets of blue, violet, green, and gold.

Each one represented a choice made by someone who had finally looked past their block.

"It's not a thing anymore " Katie said one night, her head on my shoulder.

"It's a thing. It is messy isn't it?"

"It's the most beautiful mess I've ever seen " I replied.

As I looked at the city I noticed something strange in the distance.

- It was a block that was still orange.
- It was Store #4482.
- The ruins of my coffee shop had been fixed back into their original state.
- The LED lights were on. I could feel the familiar rhythm in the air.

I realized then that the old system had not fully gone away.

They were keeping one part alive a test group for their next experiment.

They were waiting for our collective thing to become messy too inefficient.
They were waiting for us to want the way back.

I felt the pull of the spotlight.

I felt the desire to go back to my life.

I missed the safety of what I knew.

"Jimmy? What are you looking at?" Katie asked.

"an old system " I said, pulling my gaze away.

"Just a part of me that I'm still learning to let go of."

I realized then that we only see what we want to see.

Today I wanted to see the mess.

I wanted to see the void.

I wanted to see everything.

The Control Group at Store #4482 changed everything for our resistance.

We were not just building a New Community we were also keeping a
Firewall of Awareness.

This meant we knew the Board was watching us from their module waiting
for our Collective Canvas to become too confusing or too Un-rendered.

They wanted us to want the sequence again to want the safety of the four
blocks.

I spent my evenings on the roof of the building watching the city Re-render.

It was a beautiful process.

The Orange Horizon was being replaced by different horizons.

Pockets of blue, violet, green, and gold. Each one showed a choice made by
a person who had finally dared to look past their programming.

One night Katie said to me "It is not a Global Rendering anymore Jimmy."
She was resting her head on my shoulder.

Her purple hair smelled like rain and linseed oil, which felt more real than
any fragrance from a company.

"It is a Collective Canvas " she said. "It is messy is it not?"

I replied, "It is the most beautiful mess I have ever seen."

I was looking at the blocks.

As I looked at the city I wanted to go back to the fourth block.

I wanted to put on the apron and calibrate the Mastrena II.

I missed the safety of knowing what to do.

I missed the four blocks that I was used to.

I realized then that the Lens was not a tool from the company it was something that my mind was addicted to.

When I was free I was still looking for a sequence to follow.

I picked up a charcoal stick. Drew a neon green line on the roof. The line cut through the reflection of the distant store.

I whispered, "Everything has a place." This time it felt like I was choosing to say it not doing what I was told. ". My place is in a mess."

But I knew that to stay in the mess I had to understand why I was afraid of it. I needed to write down the Syntax Error that had freed us not for the Millions but for myself. I needed to make sure the Shadow never came back to control the manager.

I turned to Katie. "We need to start an archive " I said. "A record of everything the Board tried to make us forget. We need a History of the Rendering."

Katie said, "The Millions are already telling their stories, Jimmy. They are just waiting for someone to write them down."

Her eyes were bright, with a kind of focus.

I looked at my hands, which were covered in the dust of the city and the ink of the world.

I was ready to write down the stories of a world that did not want to be controlled.

Chapter 6

The project to document the History of the Rendering started in the basement of the library-bakery, which we called the Void Archive.

I used my Computer Science skills to create a physical repository of the Millions.

I did not want to forget the White Sneakers the 152-degree milk or the Ledger of Souls. I wanted to remind people of our past so we could protect our freedom. If we knew how we were captured we would be better equipped to protect us from why we are free.

I spent my days talking to the Shadows and Architects.

I listened to their stories of the 24-hour grind the Vibrant lies and the moment their lenses finally cracked.

Each story was a piece of Finite Data that I added to the archive building a mosaic of experience.

One afternoon while I was coding the Ashley Subroutine a woman walked into the archive.

She was not wearing a plum-colored silk tunic or a grey coat.

She was wearing a white dress that looked like it was made of un-rendered static.

It was Sarah.

She did not speak.

She just walked to the center of the room.

Stood there her hands moving in a circular motion like she was wiping a counter that was not there.

"Sarah?" I whispered, my lens widening in a mix of pity and recognition.

She turned toward me her Shadow face flickering.

For a split second the static.

I saw her not as the predator she was at the store but as a victim of her own ambition.

She had wanted to be the Master badly that she had become a Mechanism.

"The AWT is at four minutes " she whispered, her voice a failing digital synthesis.

"The engagement is lacking we need a recovery protocol."

"There is no AWT Sarah " I said, walking toward her my bare feet silent on the floor. "There are the dust and the choices we make. You can take off the shoes. You can choose to be un-rendered. You do not have to be a mechanism."

I reached out to touch her hand.

My fingers passed through her like smoke.

She was a Ghost of the old world, a warning of what happens when you give your vision to someone else.

"Everything has a place " she murmured her features dissolving back into grey static.

She walked out of the archive.

Disappeared into the city.

I watched her go.

I realized that Sarah was the final reflection I needed.

She was the mirror of my four blocks.

She showed me the danger of the spotlight and the tragedy of the gaze.

I went back to my workstation.

Added a new section to the archive: *THE COST, OF THE SEQUENCE*.

The archive. So did my understanding of the Global Rendering.

I started to notice a pattern in the data I got from the Boards server.

There was a Primary Recursive Loop that controlled how the city looked.

A set of instructions that made peoples brains filter out anything that did not fit the Vibrant Palette. I called it the Lens Algorithm.

I realized that my Overclocking did not actually get rid of the loop. I just made a mistake in the code that let people see the static.

The algorithm was still running in the background.

It was like a ghost waiting for the Board to fix it from a backup.

If I wanted to free the city I had to get rid of the code at the root.

Someone said, "You are trying to solve a problem that does not want to be solved Jimmy." The voice came from the shadows of the archive.

I looked up.

Saw Ashley.

She was wearing her Architect suit the grey silk that absorbed the light.

Her eyes were glowing with a violet light.

I said, "I thought you left the Board." My hand went to the Execute key on my terminal.

She said "I did. The Administrator Lens is part of my rendering now. I can see the code Jimmy. I can see what you are doing. You are trying to delete the Bias of the Observer."

I said, "I am trying to give them the truth."

Ashley said "The truth is too big for a brain Jimmy. That is why we made the lenses. Without the filters the Millions would go crazy. They would be overwhelmed by everything."

I said "They are already Ashley. They are overwhelmed by the lie. They are tired of trying to fit their lives into four blocks. They would rather be messy than managed."

Ashley looked at the screen where Sarah's face was.

Her violet eyes scanned the history of the de-rendered.

She said "You think you can build a world without order? A world where everyone sees something. "

I said "I think a world where everyone sees something different is the only world worth living in. It is called a Perspective. Not a Palette."

Ashley said "If you delete the algorithm you will get rid of the light for good. The city will look grey. The stars will look cold. The bread will just be flour and water."

I said, "Then we will learn how to make it beautiful ourselves."

I hit the Execute command.

The library did not disappear.

The violet light in Ashleys eyes went away.

Her charcoal suit turned into a grey dress.

She looked at her hands then at me.

She looked real.

She said, "What did you do?" Her voice sounded like a voice for the first time.

I said "I deleted the Authorized Rendering. I gave the city back, to the Millions. Now we have to see if they are ready to look."

The deletion of the Authorized Rendering did not happen at once. It was a process of decay. The Vibrant light did not just turn off; it faded like a dying sun. Over weeks the city of the Millions changed in a big way.

- The billboards that used to promise Engagement and Community were now empty metal and plastic slabs. Their digital displays could not find a signal.
- The traffic lights stopped dancing. Began to blink in response to the actual flow of the streets.
- The Orange Horizon that had hovered over the block for twelve years finally set. It revealed a night sky that was deep, scary, and full of stars.

I stood in the center of the block. My bare feet felt the texture of the cracked pavement. The Vibrant Palette was gone. The world looked grey. It was really grey. It was the grey of stone, the grey of concrete. It was the grey of a world that did not need to be painted to be valid.

People wandered the streets in shock. Without the Boards filters they saw everything at once. They saw the rust on the fire hydrants and the trash in the gutters. They saw the Static in the eyes of their neighbors. They saw the Millions as scared and beautiful people.

"Everything is so... Loud " a man whispered. He leaned against a lamp post near the Hub. He held his head in his hands. His eyes were wide with much information.

"That's the sound of the world breathing " I said. "You've been holding your breath for a time. Just take it slow. Focus on one thing at a time."

"What thing?" he asked. He looked at me with a gaze.

"Whatever you want to see " I replied. "It's your view now. You're in control."

I realized then that being the Curator of the Void was a responsibility. We had to teach the Millions how to see things their way. We had to show them that focusing on one thing was not a cage if they chose to do it. If they chose to focus on the 152-degree milk or the seventeen cracks it had to be their choice.

I spent my nights at the Hub. It was now a real building, with books and flour. We did not have an espresso-terminal anymore; we had a fireplace and a real library. We were the center of the Un-rendering movement. People came to learn the Syntax of Choice.

Katie and Angel were there. Their hands were stained with paint and charcoal. They were not building a virus; they were building a community. They were painting murals that did not pulse or flicker. They simply sat on the walls. Waiting to see.

The 'Un-rendering' brought a kind of silence. It was not a silence. It was full of possibilities. The city of the Millions did not sound like a machine anymore. I heard birds chirping in the parks. I heard water dripping in the subways. I heard kids laughing. They had never seen the orange sky.

I started a project at the Hub. It was called the 'Library of Perspectives.' I wanted to collect peoples stories. Not as data. As a record of what they did. I wanted to know what they saw when they looked past the block. I wanted to know what kept them alive during the Boards rule.

People come to the library every day. They told me their stories. A woman worked in a 'Vibrant' office for twenty years. She never saw her husband's face. A man was a 'Shadow', for ten years. He survived on the patterns of the subway tiles.

I authored their stories down. I used a typewriter. I did not want to code. I wanted ink. I wanted to leave a mark.

One morning a man walked into the library.

I recognized him.

He was not wearing his suit or mask.

He wore a hoodie and scuffed boots.

He looked like a person.

It was the Auditor.

The man who used to be the Auditor.

He did not have rectangle eyes.

He had eyes.

They were tired and sad.

He sat down.

Looked at his hands.

They were shaking.

"I... I... "I do not know " he whispered.

"The sequence is gone " I said. "You don't have to find it."

"But I don't know how " he said.

He looked up at me.

His eyes were desperate.

I wanted to give him answers.

I felt like being his boss.

I did not. I pulled out a charcoal stick.

I put it on the table.

"Everything has a place " I said.

"Your place is here. On this page."

I pointed to a sheet of paper.

"Don't look for the sequence. Just draw what you want."

He looked at the charcoal.

Then he started drawing.

Chapter 7

The Auditor did not draw a kind of gate.

He did not draw a line where the sky meets the ground.

He drew a curve that was not perfect and was a little shaky.

This curve was a bridge.

I left the Auditor.

I went back to my machine that I wrote on.

I added a book to the collection of books called the 'Library of Perspectives.

The name of this book was *THE DE-FRAGMENTATION OF THE DAEMON*.

I realized that we only see what we want to see.

Today I wanted to see the Auditor become a real person.

I wanted to see the city become a home where people can live.

The third year of the New Community was the year when everyone worked together to create something.

The city was no longer just grey.

It was like a party with different colors everywhere.

Everywhere I looked I saw people expressing their ideas.

Some streets were happy and colorful others were serious and simple.

Each one was a choice made by a real person.

I was still the person in charge of the space but my project at the center of the city had grown.

The 'Library of Perspectives was now a collection of information from all over the world that I got from other cities that had changed.

I was making a kind of map of the world that did not have any borders.

As the world became more different I started to notice a new problem.

Some people were getting too used to the noise.

They were so afraid of the people in charge that they did not want to create anything.

They lived in spaces their homes and lives were just grey and confusing.

They were the opposite of the people who were invisible; they were choosing not to exist.

"They are afraid to make a choice Jimmy " Angel said one evening when we were standing on the roof of the center of the city.

She was painting a picture on the clouds using a special light machine that I made for her.

"They are afraid that if they draw a line the people in charge will find a way to use it against them. They think the empty space is the safe place left."

"A line is a line, Angel " I said, looking out at the city.

"It is not a trap unless you let someone else decide how to get out."

"But how do we teach them that?" she asked, her light changing between green and purple.

"How do we make them see that the empty space is a place to create, not a place to hide?"

I thought about the Auditor and the bridge he drew.

I thought about the milk and the cracks.

I realized that the problem was not the way we see things it was the person in charge.

People did not need to be told what to see they needed to be told that it was okay to see.

I decided to start something 'The Daily Rendering'.

I did not send out a message on a computer. I sent out letters, written on real paper with real ink.

I sent them to the people living in the noise to the people hiding in the spaces.

The letters had a piece of paper and a charcoal stick.

On the envelope I wrote the important words: *Everything has a place.. Its place is wherever you choose to put it.*

The Un-rendering brought a kind of silence to the city of the Millions.

This silence was not empty it was full of things that could happen.

Without the noise of the Vibrant Palette the city started to sound like a real place. I could hear birds chirping in the parks water dripping in the tunnels and children laughing. These children had never seen the orange sky.

I started a project at the Rendering Hub. I called it the Library of Perspectives.

I wanted to collect stories from the people who lived in the Millions.

I did not want to use these stories to make a computer program.

I wanted to keep them as a record of what people can do.

I wanted to know what people saw when they looked beyond what they were supposed to see.

I wanted to know what kept them alive during the years when the Board was in charge.

Every day people come to the Hub.

Tell me their stories.

One woman had worked in an office for twenty years.

She realized she had never actually seen her husband's face.

One man had been a Shadow for ten years.

He survived by finding patterns in the subway tiles.

I wrote down all of their stories.

I used a typewriter, not a computer.

I wanted to use ink, not code.

I wanted something that would leave a mark.

One morning a man I knew came to the library.

He was not wearing a suit or a mask.

He was wearing a hoodie and boots.

He looked like a student from The SUNY College.

It was the Auditor.

At least it was the man who used to be the Auditor.

He did not have eyes that were like orange rectangles.

He had eyes that looked tired and sad.

He sat down at a table.

Looked at his hands.

They were shaking.

"I cannot find the sequence " he whispered. His voice sounded really not like a computer.

"The sequence is gone " I told him. "You do not have to find it."

He said, "I do not know how to look. I have spent a hundred years helping other people see what they were supposed to see. I do not know how to see myself."

I looked at him.

For a moment I felt like I wanted to help him. I wanted to give him a sequence to tell him what to do.

I did not.

I took a charcoal stick out of my pocket.

I put it on the table in front of him.

"Everything has a place."

I spoke. "Your place is here on this paper."

I pointed to a piece of paper. "Do not look for the sequence. Just look at the paper. Draw what you want to see."

He looked at the charcoal for a time.

Then he started to draw. He did not draw a line or a logic gate.

He drew a curve.

It was a bridge.

I left him there. I went back to my typewriter. I started a book in the Library of Perspectives.

I called it *THE DE-FRAGMENTATION, OF THE DAEMON*.

I realized that we only see what we want to see.

Today I wanted to see the Auditor become a person.

I wanted to see the city become a home.

The third year of the New Community was the year of the Collective Canvas.
The city was not grey anymore.

It was full of color and life.

Everywhere I looked I saw the Millions doing their thing.

Some streets were bright and happy others were quiet and serious, but each one was special in its way.

I was still the Curator of the Void.

My project at the Rendering Hub was getting bigger.

The Library of Perspectives was now a collection of ideas from all over the world.

We were getting information from cities that had successfully changed the way they did things.

I was making a kind of map that showed how everything was connected.

As the world was changing I started to notice a new problem.

Some of the Millions were getting Addicted to the Static.

They were so scared of the Boards rules that they did not want to do anything all.

They lived in spaces with nothing but grey noise all around them.

"They are afraid to make a choice Jimmy " Angel said one evening as we stood on the roof of a building.

She was taking a picture on the clouds using a special light projector that I had made for her.

"They are afraid that if they draw a line the Board will use it against them."

"A line is a line, Angel " I said.

Looking out at the city.

"It is not a trap unless someone else decides to make one."

"But how do we teach them that?" she asked, her light changing from green to purple. "How do we make them see that the empty space is a place to create, not a place to hide?"

I thought about the Auditor and the bridge he had made.

I thought about the milk and the cracks.

I realized that the problem was not the way we looked at things it was the person in charge.

The Millions did not need to be told what to do they needed to be told that it was okay to be themselves.

I decided to start something on the Hub: The Daily Rendering.

I did not send out a message on a tablet.

I did not send a note.

I sent out letters, written on real paper with real ink.

I sent them to the people living in the static to the people hiding in the spaces.

The letters were simple.

They had a piece of paper and a charcoal stick on the envelope I wrote something that had helped me.

Everything has a place and its place is wherever you choose to put it.

I was giving them the power to create.

I was giving them the permission to be real.

At first nothing happened.

Then the static started to clear.

In the grey buildings small windows started to appear.

A child drew a picture of a sun.

A woman drew a picture of a flower.

A man drew a map of a garden.

The Millions were starting to look.

They were starting to make their small victories.

I looked at my hands.

I was still Jimmy.

I still knew about the cracks.

I was also the Curator.

I was the one who kept the doors open so that others could find their way.

I realized then that we only see what we want to see.

Today I wanted to see the city wake up one line, at a time.

Chapter 8

The 'Daily Rendering' initiative was a success.

It brought a new threat to the city of the Millions.

As people became more confident in their vision the leftover corporate subroutines of the Board started to react.

They did not come with an Auditor or a 'Global Remodel' this time.

They came with 'The Optimization of Memory.'

I started getting reports from the Hub about people who were 'Losing their Lenses.'

They would wake up one morning.

Find that they could not remember the 'Un-rendering' or the Underworld. They would look at their charcoal sketches.

See only flickering grey noise.

Their brains were being fixed by a ghost protocol that was still running in the city's code, a leftover from the twelve-year sequence.

Katie told me one afternoon her purple hair looking dull in the sun that it was a 'Self-Healing' script. She was holding a man's sketch.

A drawing of a park bench.

But as I watched the lines were fading, turning back into the white of the paper.

"The system thinks the rebellion is a mistake that it needs to fix " she said.

"It's trying to restore the Millions to their state without them even knowing it."

I said, "We have to stop the script " as I watched the sketch disappear.

Angel said, "The script isn't in a server anymore."

Her hands were covered in neon paint. "It's in the people.

It is a kind of code that is spread through the silence we create.

Every time someone misses the Boards order the script.

Deletes the deviation."

I realized then that the final battle was not for the city; it was for our memories.

If the Millions forgot why they had dared to look past the block the Board would win without doing anything.

They would just wait for things to go back to normal.

I went to my typewriter and started writing.

I did not write code; I wrote 'The Book of the Lens.' I wrote down everything.

I wrote about the sneakers in the gutter the neon green milk and the French Workshop.

I wrote about Sarah and Mrs. Rosa and the Auditor.

I wrote about how people were controlled and how they made choices.

I was not just writing a history.

I was building a protection.

I was creating a sequence of words that would be too specific, too messy, and too human for any self-healing script to delete.

"We have to share the book " I told my friends.

"Not as a file but as a real book. We have to make it something they can touch something they can smell something that leaves a mark on their hands and minds."

We spent months printing the book in the bakery wing of the Hub using ink and real paper.

We did not use a machine; we printed each page by hand.

Every letter was a choice.

Every line was a challenge to the Boards silence.

We shared the books through the 'Daily Rendering' network.

We gave them to people in the spaces to people in the parks and to people who were starting to forget their own names.

The Book of the Lens became the foundation of the New Community.

It was not a history book it was a Guide to the Peripheral.

People used it to recognize the signs of the Boards subroutines to protect their own small worlds from the Self-Healing scripts.

The city of the Millions was finally its own.

I spent my year as the Curator of the Void mapping the global archipelago of resistance.

The Library of Perspectives was now a network of libraries, bakeries and Un-rendering Hubs that stretched across every continent.

We were no longer a Syntax Error we were a new operating system for the planet built on the principles of choice and diversity.

As the world became more unsynchronized I started to notice a final Null Pointer in my own life.

I was so focused on mapping the world on documenting the rebellion and on protecting the Millions that I had stopped looking at my horizon.

I was still living in the Hub counting the books and measuring the temperature of the air in the archives.

Jimmy you are becoming a monument again Ashley said one evening appearing at my office door.

She was wearing a hand-woven dress of un-rendered grey.

She looked like a person who had found her own sequence her hair loose and her eyes clear.

I looked up from my typewriter.

I have been working on a chapter: *THE OPTIMIZATION OF FREEDOM*.

I am just documenting the progress, Ashley.

Everything has a place.

I need to make sure the sequence is preserved.

But your place is not just in this building Jimmy said, walking over to the window that looked out onto the city.

You have spent fifteen years in cages.

The coffee shop, the bakery, the college, the Boards facility.

Even this Hub is a cage if you never leave it.

You are still managing the mess of living in it.

I looked at the city outside.

The Millions were living their lives.

They were building, creating, and choosing.

They did not need me to curate their horizons anymore.

They were doing it themselves using the tools I had given them.

I gave Rosa a broom today I said, a smile touching my lips.

She asked for a management position.

I told her we do not have those anymore.

I told her the floor needed sweeping.

She actually did it.

She is learning the rhythm of the wood.

Rosa is finding her rendering Ashley said softly. What about you Jimmy?
When was the last time you looked at something you did not have to document?

I looked at my hands. They were covered in ink and charcoal.

They were the hands of a curator and a programmer.

They were also the hands of a man who had never actually seen the ocean except, in a mural.

The Book of the Lens is finished I realized.

The Millions have the code.

They have the memory.

They do not need a curator anymore.

No Ashley agreed.

They need you to be Jimmy.

Just Jimmy.

I stood up. Walked to the closet. I pulled out my work boots.

The ones I had bought for college.

I did not look for the sneakers.

I did not look for the apron.
I was ready to leave the archive behind.
I walked out of the library-bakery at dawn.
The door was left unlocked for whoever wanted to enter.
I did not look at the voids in the walls.
I did not check the AWT for the bread being baked in the hearth.
I walked toward the edge of the city.
I walked toward the place where the road did not have a sequence.
"Where are you going?" Katie asked.
She appeared in the hallway as I reached the entrance.
Her purple hair was glowing in the light of the morning.
"I am going to look past the block " I said.
A real sense of liberation finally settled over me.
"I am going to see the rest of the world."
"But who will manage the archive?" she asked.
Her eyes were wide with a mixture of fear and excitement.
"Nobody " I said. "Let it be a void.
Let the Millions find their way through it.
Everything has a place Katie, and the archives place is in the past.
We do not need a curator to tell us we are free."
I walked onto the sidewalk. My boots hit the pavement.
I did not count the cracks.
I did not measure the distance.
I just followed the sun.
The road out of the city was a Syntax Error that stretched for miles.
There were no billboards, no traffic lights, and no orange horizons.
There was the land, the sky, and the silence.

It was a world that had not been Optimized by the Board.
It was a place where the Vibrant Palette had never reached.
I walked for three days.
I ate the bread I had carried from the Hub.
I drank from the streams that were not part of any municipal data set.
I slept on the ground without counting the blades of grass.
I was learning how to be a Natural Observer.
I was seeing the world without a lens.
On the day I reached the ocean.
I had read about the ocean in the Library of Perspectives.
I had seen sketches of it in Angels murals.
I had never actually stood before it. I stood on a cliff of grey stone and
looked out at the horizon.
The ocean was not a blur. It was not a filter.
It was a deep and terrifyingly beautiful canvas of blue and white.
I could see the waves crashing against the rocks.
Each wave was a movement.
I could smell the salt, the rot, and the life.
I sat on the edge of the cliff. Looked at the water for a long time.
I felt the lens in my mind trying to find a pattern.
I felt it trying to calculate the frequency of the waves.
I felt it trying to fit the Atlantic into a box.
The ocean was too big.
It was too messy.
It was too real.
I realized then that the Board had not just been controlling the city.
The Board had been controlling the Idea of the world.
They had made us afraid of the infinite.

The infinite cannot be managed.
They had made us love the four blocks.
The four blocks could be owned.
I reached into my pocket.
I pulled out my phone.
It was the one, scuffed and old.
I looked at the screen.
There was no signal.
There were no messages.
There was no module.
I threw the phone into the ocean.
I watched Fall. It was a black rectangle disappearing into the white foam.
I did not need the code anymore.
I did not need the archive.
I was Jimmy.
Just Jimmy.
For the first time, in thirty years I was un-synced.

Chapter 9

I stood on the beach for a time.

The cold Atlantic water made my feet numb.

I could not feel the weight of my past. The city of the Millions was behind me.

It was a memory of orange and grey.

I was no longer the person in charge of things.

I was a man standing at the edge of the world.

The world was moving with the tide.

As the sun started to rise I saw something on the sand.

It was half-buried in the things the tide had left behind.

It was a shoe. A bright white sneaker.

It looked like it was brand new.

It was not dirty or old.

It was the shoe I saw in the gutter twelve years ago.

It was the shoe that I kept thinking about.

I walked over to the shoe.

The wet sand was squishing between my toes.

I did not feel sick this time.

I just felt curious.

I picked up the shoe.

It was heavy and cold.

I looked at the threads that held it together.

I was looking for something.

There was nothing.

It was a shoe.

A regular shoe made of rubber and cloth.

I looked up at the cliff.
I saw a woman standing there.
She was wearing a coat.
Her hair was blowing in the wind.
She looked at me for a moment.
Then she.
Walked away.
She disappeared into the distance.
I wondered who she was.
Was it Sarah?
Was it Ashley?
Was it Katie?
It did not matter.
She was a person.
She had her own life to live.
She was part of the world that I could finally see.
I looked at the white sneaker in my hand.
I thought about the people in the city.
They were still wearing shoes like this one.
They were still doing the things. I thought about the Auditor. He was trying to learn how to be real.
I put the shoe back on the sand.
I did not throw it away.
I did not keep it.
I just put it where I found it.
I said to myself everything has a place.
The shoes place was in the past.
I walked back up the cliff. My bare feet were finding the path.

I did not look back at the shoe.

I did not look for the woman.

I looked at the sky.

The sun was rising.

The light was beautiful.

I realized that I was free. I could choose what I wanted to see. I could choose to see the world.

I could choose to see the mess. I could choose to see nothing.

I reached the top of the cliff. I looked out at the land. It was not empty. It was just waiting to be written.

I was Jimmy.

Just Jimmy.

I was ready to start my life.

I walked west leaving the ocean and the city behind.

The land was really beautiful.

There were hills of grass that moved in the wind like waves. There were trees with twisted branches that were alive.

There were rivers that wound through the valleys in a path, and nobody had mapped them out.

There were no signs, no traffic lights, and no fancy colors. This was a world that just existed that is all.

I spent the year of my life walking around. I did not have a plan. I did not have a place to go. I just followed the sun and the stars.

I learned how to sleep on the ground without worrying about how hard it was.

I learned how to eat berries and roots without thinking about how good they were for me.

I learned how to listen to birds without trying to figure out what they were saying.

I was learning how to see the world. I was learning how to look at things without getting in the way.

In the villages I walked through I saw that people were living in a way.
They were building their houses out of stone and wood and each one was unique. They were growing their food and telling their own stories.

They were not a crowd they were individuals.

They were making their way, and they did not need anyone to tell them what to do.

One evening I came to a village at the foot of a mountain range.

In the center of the village was a building that looked like a library and a bakery combined.

I went inside. The smell of bread and old books hit me like a memory.

A woman was standing behind the counter putting bread into bags for some kids.

She was wearing a blue dress that she had made herself.

She looked up.

I saw her face.

It was not a face I had seen before it was a face with its story.

She looked at me with a happy gaze.

"Are you just passing through?" she asked, her voice sounding like the wind.

"I am just walking " I said and I felt like I belonged.

"We have been expecting you Jimmy," She gave me a loaf of bread.

"We heard that you might come this way.

We heard that you taught us that a blank space can be beautiful."

I looked at the bread.

I just took a bite.

It was the thing I had ever tasted because it was real.

I stayed in the village that night. I sat by the fire.

Told them stories about my life.

I told them about the things that had happened to me.

I was not trying to teach them anything I was just telling them stories.

As the stars came out I realized that we only see what we want to see.
That day I wanted to see the truth.
I closed my eyes and for the time, in a long time I did not see anything fake.
I saw the darkness.
In the darkness I finally found some peace.

THE END.

